

Budweiser in the 1990s. And in 2002 the board of directors named him CEO of the company.

In 2007 Anheuser-Busch turned a \$2.1 billion dollar profit on \$16.7 billion in sales. But the company failed to expand internationally. And consolidation in the brewing industry meant it was just a matter of time before the company became a takeover target. Rival brewer InBev made a series of unsolicited bids, with a final offer of \$70 a share—\$20 over the share price at the time. It was irresistible for the Anheuser-Busch shareholders and its board.

August IV tried to resist the takeover. He said he would have given his life to keep the company from merging. But he was powerless.

But that misses the point. The demise of the Busch dynasty began years earlier when the family sold its controlling ownership stake. August IV made \$100 million from the sale. But despite the cash, he is reported to have become depressed and reclusive after the deal. After all, his family legacy—his very identity—had been lost.

In December 2010, a staff member made a 911 call from August IV's mansion in Missouri. August IV's 27-year-old girlfriend was found dead of a drug overdose—a combination of the opioid oxycodone and cocaine. The windows of that wing of the house were blacked out, and loaded guns were found in the bathroom. The police declined to press charges. But there is an ongoing civil suit against August IV.

This is clearly a sad story. But it contains an important message. And it is this: Once the focus of your family's productive life is gone, the demons start to come out.

Never sell controlling ownership of the family business unless there are no other options.

A GREAT FAMILY BUSINESS LOST

Maybe it's something about the alcohol business, but the famous Guinness family of Ireland lost ownership, after seven generations, in a similar way